

Cover story SLUMDOG MILLIONAIRE



ASHOK AMRITRAJ

Timing is everything

It's part of the Obama optimism, which wouldn't have worked in the Clinton era

In life, timing is everything. *Slumdog Millionaire* is one of the best films of the year but it has to be said that several good films have not been nominated for Best Picture, whether it is Clint Eastwood's *Gran Torino*, the animated *Wall-E* or even Chris Nolan's *The Dark Knight*. But it comes at a time when America is undergoing an enormous recession. People are losing 60,000 jobs a month, they are having to give up their homes. A film like this comes along and reminds them that no matter how bad their lives are, 200-300 million people in India have it worse, and are still smiling. Its incredible momentum is part of what made Barack Obama President. It's the yearning for hope. Will it have the impact on its decade that Dickie Attenborough's *Gandhi* did in 1982? I don't think so. But it is by far the Academy's favourite this year. I wish an Indian could have made it but in Bollywood everyone seems to focus on the stars, not the story. What impact will it have on India? No not like *Braveheart* which saw a 400 per cent rise in tourism to Scotland but more an opportunity to take India's experimental films by younger filmmakers to a western audience. This could have hap-



PATEL (LEFT) AND IRRFAN

pened when *Gandhi*, *Passage to India* and *Jewel in the Crown* were made in quick succession, in the '80s but India's wasn't ready for it infrastructurally. Now I believe it is. It also proves Hollywood is the fairest system in the world. It offers a worldwide stage for talent. The success of the film has shown you can make a movie anywhere in the world and still have it seen. And loved.

The writer is chairman of Hyde Park Entertainment



MADHUR MITTAL

“I turned down Ram Gopal Varma's film. I don't want to be typecast.”

When Anil Kapoor met my dad, he told him your son is Amitabh Bachchan." Indeed, Mittal, a 1997 winner of *Boogie Woogie*, is the dark horse in the movie, and kept away from the spotlight focused firmly on the lead couple. Ask him about his absence from the studio-generated hype, and he shrugs: "The studio wanted to promote it as a love story." He missed out on the SAG awards because of visa problems but is all set to wear what his mother designs for him to the Oscars. The little boy from Agra has been working since he was four, having done more than 1,000 dance shows as Junior Michael Jackson. He's been a child actor in two films and played a cricketer in the little seen *Say Salaam India* but is now in the running to get an agent internationally. He's reading five scripts currently and is delighted that he beat bold face Bollywood names Shreyas Talpade and Kunal Khemu to get the role of Salim. Especially, since he had to endure 12 stitches and an eight-month long recovery in the middle of the audition after a bike accident lodged the nut and bolt of an autorickshaw in his forehead.

ANIL KAPOOR, 49

“Larry King told me I've really milked my role.”

He came and sat down on the floor, says Anil Kapoor, demonstrating how Emma Thompson talked to him in first class for over an hour on the flight from New York to London. Kapoor is soaking in the appreciation, flying all over the world at his own expense, being on *Regis and Kelly* one morning and taping an episode of *My City My Life* for CNN another. At 49, after 25 years of doing fine but under-recognised work, from *Woh Saat*



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